

60 revolutions

WINDS OF CHANGE

FASHION

By Kimi Dangor

Just as fortune favours the bold, fashion favours the brave. Or so Rohit Khosla discovered when he set out to become India's first fashion designer, a term unknown in the times of handy *darzis* and flourishing export houses. While others may have given up sartorial pursuits in the absence of technical training, the Delhi boy went on to create his own fashion footprint and co-founded Ensemble, Tarun and Sal Tahiliani's fashion store.

Fashion may be fickle, but its rise in India has been nothing short of cutting edge. While two decades ago, Ensemble started out with five labels—Tarun Tahiliani, Rohit Khosla, Neil Bieff, Amaya, Abu Jani & Sandeep Khosla, today it has four outlets and over 90 labels on its racks. "Paying anything beyond Rs 1,000 for an outfit was unheard of then. Ensemble brought in the concept of high fashion wear," says fashion writer Meher Castelino.

The desi fashion industry is estimated to grow to Rs 1,000 crore by 2010 (according to a FDCI-KPMG study in 2003). A lot of the credit for the country's couture revolution goes to a 1986 blueprint that first envisaged the possibility of what went on to become the National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT). A fecund garment export industry was bringing in foreign exchange but was sorely lacking in know-how. "So, the government decided to develop textile and garment manufacturing sectors. NIFT was set up on paper in 1986, courses started in 1987 and the first batch graduated in 1989," recalls Rathi Vinay Jha, director general, Fashion Design Council of India (FDCI). "Fashion began to be taken seriously for the first time," adds Jha.

"Though I firmly believe that
TRENDY ALTERATION: India's booming fashion industry owes much to NIFT

creativity is in my blood, professionally, my early design years belong to the institute," says couturier J.J. Valaya in his style annals VU.

Sure enough, the class of 1991 saw talents like Valaya, Ashish Soni and Ranna Gill graduate to independent labels. Now with centres in Delhi, Chennai, Hyderabad, Gandhinagar, Kolkata, Mumbai, Bangalore and Rai Bareilly, India's booming fashion industry owes much to the institute, with talent springing from small towns across the country.

Even as the fashion fraternity united under the aegis of the FDCI in 1998, the first ever Lakme India Fashion Week was held in Delhi in 2000, where 33 designers showcased their work over seven days. But post a persistent six-year-itch and a parting of ways between the FDCI, sponsor Lakme and event manager IMG in 2005, India's fashion watchers were to witness four fashion weeks a year with both Delhi and Mumbai acquiring Wills Lifestyle India Fashion Week and Lakme Fashion Week, respectively. And with the last season featuring nearly 60 shows, with over 90 labels over 10 days, fashion is all set to rise to the occasion.

Abu-Sandeep's tryst with Hollywood, Ritu Beri's Jean-Louis Scherrer stint, Manish Arora's Parisian curtain call, Tahiliani's ramp romp in Milan—fashion's flings with international adulation have been many, even as the market at home matures. Today, Ensemble has company with multi-designer stores like Melange, Kimaya, Aza, Ogaan, Amara, and Elahe opening up, not to mention signature stores by most of India's designing denizen.

As global brands sashay onto the Indian retail ramp and the mode madness intensifies, designers are getting more media savvy, equipped with international fashion week festoons, trend forecasts and pushy PR professionals. Here's an industry that refuses to be pinned down.

PARMESHWAR GODREJ, socialite, 1987

"The younger generation is becoming increasingly aware about being well turned out."

HEMANT CHAWLA